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21 October 2022

The Elimination of General Studies at MUN

Over Nineteen thousand students (Sorensen) have chosen MUN to become their eventual alma mater. This number is gradually increasing, with enrollment rising ten percent every five years. Despite this population increase, all students must complete their general year, regardless of their program, financial class, or prior academic success. For many, this isn't an issue. They have a pool of money to dip into to pay for courses, and can handle the additional course workload. However, there are a number of students who lack adequate finances and non-material resources. This makes a post secondary education less of a right, and more of an extortionate privilege. The solution to this problem is clear; The General Studies year should be eliminated from all MUN first year programs. The additional courses that students are required to take are often too much additional expense, and their addition takes away from the overall time students can dedicate to their main courses. Despite the minimal benefits from paying hundreds of thousands to take these general courses, their existence helps to offer a smoother transition from high school to university.

The typical workload for a full time first year MUN student is three to five courses (Memorial University). Of these courses, it is rarely the case that all are necessary for acceptance into a specific faculty. Take, for example, a first year student who is attempting to enter into the Department of Computer Science. Of the ten courses that the university recommends, only six are "required" for entry into the program (Memorial University). The other forty percent of

courses still have to be done, but offer nothing to the student in terms of program entry. In the Fall semester of 2022, a student can expect to pay (in CAD) anywhere from \$256 to \$2000 per course (Memorial University), varying upon student circumstances. If a student has to take four extra courses, the additional cost could range anywhere from \$1024 to \$8000. Having to pay such a substantial amount of money to do “mandatory” courses is near coercion, and is a tax that many cannot afford. If there was great importance to do these courses, the cost would be justified. This is not true, as regardless of the program a student is entering, these courses are nothing more than general.

The commodity which many consider to be as valuable as money, is time. In an article by Simon Fraser University, it is recommended that students study each of their courses for “2-3 hours per credit per week” (McGee-Thompson). This number becomes 6-9 hours, as most first year courses amount to three credit hours. If a first year student is attempting to enter a faculty, and did not have to complete general courses, they would have three courses to study every week. Based upon Simon Fraser’s recommendation, a student would spend around 18-27 hours per week studying. This is a reasonable number, as the student could study for around three to five hours each day. The problem arises when the course load is increased from three classes per semester to five. An extra 12-18 hours of study are then recommended per week, or 30-45 hours overall. In a study by Nick Huntington-Klein and Andrew Gill in 2021, it was proved that there is little variation in a student’s grades based strictly on course load, rather more variation based upon a student’s personality and mental health (Huntington-Klein and Gill). So although a student with five courses and strong personality may not see a drop in marks, an anxious student may experience detrimental decreases in their marks, possibly ruining their chances of being accepted into a faculty. A University should give all students an even chance in succeeding, so

removing the general courses from a student's course load would give everyone more time to study their important courses, and have a less adverse effect on their mental health.

For all the downsides of a general year, there has to be redeeming qualities which allow it to remain common practice. The most beneficial general year trait is the transition it provides from high school to university. In recent years, Newfoundland's Department of Education has removed public exams from all high schools in an attempt to promote mental wellbeing, and as an attempt to change the style that they assess students (Hood). Grading schemes are becoming less based upon what a student knows, and more about how hard a student tries. This change is not mutual with MUN. The jump from doing minimal work in high school, to having multiple exams per semester, is an extreme change for all students. Having a number of general courses with minimal or no exams can assist a student to better adjust to the archaic university system, rather than struggling to keep up with it in perpetuity.

University is becoming a significant period of more and more people's lives. The memories people want to associate with their post-secondary experience are all of positive nature, yet more and more are leaving university with crippling student debt, without the degree they initially wanted, and generally a bad taste in their mouth. The student experience would become more optimistic if the general year is removed. Students could more easily afford the courses they actually need, and then spend more time studying for these courses. Although this transitional period will no longer be present, its absence will separate the ambitious, hard working students from those who do not want to pursue an illustrious university degree.

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